EW 10 USES OF THE IMPERFECT TENSE

60. USES OF THE IMPERFECT TENSE

a) to describe a person or a scene

she wore a black coat	:	*Elle portait un manteau noir*
The road wound through the forest	:	*La route serpentait à travers la forêt*
The fields stretched out in front of him	:	*les champs s'étendaient devant lui*

b) to record time of day, distance or age

It was past 4 o'clock when	:	*Il était quatre heures passées quand .....*
He was eight when his father died	:	*Il avait huit ans quand son père est mort*

c) to record HABITUAL ACTION in the past over an UNDEFINED PERIOD

She went there on Saturday mornings	:	*Elle y allait le samedi matin*
Whenever they saw her	:	*Chaque fois qu'ils la voyaient*

BUT NB when the period of time is defined the verb must be in the perfect tense:

She went there every day for 5 years	:	*Elle y est allée tous les jours pendant cinq ans*
Dinosaurs lived on earth for millions of years		*Les dinosaures ont vécu sur la terre pendant des millions d'années*

61. The Imperfect is ALWAYS used

a) where English has `WAS . . . ING / WERE . . . ING' or `USED TO . . .'

b) to translate `WAS / WERE ABOUT TO' — *Il était sur le point de partir quand elle est arrivée*

c) to render a past tense after

- **comme** (`as') - **pendant que** (`while') - **juste au moment où** (`just as')

- As he got off the train he slipped	:	*Comme il descendait du train il a glissé*
- While she did the washing up I read a book		*Pendant qu'elle faisait la vaisselle j'ai lu un livre*
- Just as he stood up he heard a shout	:	*Juste au moment où il se levait il a entendu un cri*

62. Cases where the English simple past tense is NOT translated by the French Imperfect tense

i) when recording that `IT WAS' at a particular moment that an event happened

ie when the emphasis comes at the beginning of a sentence as in the following examples:

- It was last week that I saw her : *C'est la semaine dernière que je l'ai vue*
- It was in 1974 that we went there : *C'est en 1974 que nous y sommes allés*
- It was in this café that I first met her : *C'est dans ce café que je l'ai rencontrée pour la première fois*

ii) Where the past tense records a reaction, change of state or successive stages in narration

- nb the following words accompanying a verb indicate a change of state, a reaction or successive stages in the narration, and therefore dictate the use of the Perfect or Past historic

d'abord (at first) - **soudain / tout à coup** (suddenly) - **puis / ensuite** (then / next)
tout de suite (immediately) - **encore** (again) - **enfin** (finally)

- Then I was sure that ..... : *Puis j'ai été sûr que ....*

- At first he didn't want to believe me : *D'abord il n'a pas voulu me croire*

- I knew immediately that ... : *J'ai su tout de suite que ....*

Note the following example of successive stages in narration:

D'abord le professeur a frappé à la porte, puis il est entré; tout de suite il a parlé aux élèves et enfin il s'est assis

NB `WHEN s.o. WAS ---- (and then) he DID such & such a thing : this common sequence also requires the `was' to be rendered by the Perfect or Past Historic since it records a change of state

- When I was sure I left — *Quand j'ai été sûr je suis parti*
- When we were ready we went downstairs — *Quand nous avons été prêts nous sommes descendus*

iii) in contexts where there is a marker LIMITING THE DURATION (HOWEVER LONG) of an event/state/movement/action (Examples of such markers are underlined)

- There was a few moments' silence : *Il y a eu quelques moments de silence*
- There were two centuries of peace : *Il y a eu deux siècles de paix*
- Dinner that evening was much too long : *Le dîner ce soir-là a été beaucoup trop long*

iv) in passive structures where `WAS' / `WERE' record one event in the past

- She was run over by a car : *Elle a été écrasée par une voiture*
- It was built in the sixteenth century : *Il a été construit au seizième siècle*

NB DISTINGUISH between *elle était blessée* (DESCRIPTION OF STATE)
and *elle a été blessée* (THE ACTION OF BEING WOUNDED)

v) to translate `WAS / WERE BORN'

- She was born : *elle EST née* - I was born : *Je SUIS né(e)*

63. SUCH

You must distinguish whether the "such" is qualifying an **adjective** or a **noun**.
SUCH + NOUN - use one of **tel** / **telle** / **tels** / **telles** (ie it is an adjective) but pay great attention to the French word order.

- such a problem : *un tel problème* - such a house : *une telle maison*
- such problems : *de tels problèmes* - such houses : *de telles maisons*

Des must contract to **de** when it comes before a plural adjective. Since **tel** is an adjective the plural forms will always be **de tels** . . . (masculine), or **de telles** . . . (feminine)

SUCH + ADJECTIVE + NOUN - use **si**
Leave the adjective in its NORMAL POSTION and place *si* in front of it:

- a beautiful house : *une belle maison*
- such a beautiful house : *une si belle maison*
- such beautiful houses : *DE si belles maisons*

- an interesting film : *un film intéressant*
- such an interesting film : *un film si intéressant*
- such interesting films : *DES films si intéressants*

NB The position of the adjective varies, so . . .
- If it comes before the noun the plural will always be *de si* . . . + ADJ + NOUN;
- if it comes after the noun the plural will always be *des* + NOUN + *si* + ADJ